

Different STROKES

As a growing number of patients despair of mainstream medicine, alternative therapies come into their own



| By Nirmala Ravindran |

Stop," is Padmini Menon's first instruction to a client. "Stop what?" is the invariable question from the bewildered client. "Just stop," she says, with a beatific smile before beginning the session. Menon is possibly India's only trained practitioner of the Alexander Technique (AT)—a form of therapy or study used extensively in the West to regain better control over the body. While a student or patient sits on a chair, Menon will adjust his neck by an inch and change the position of his arms or feet by a few centimetres. The person is then asked to move to a couch while Menon continues her moves. The client's participation is almost minimal in a session that lasts for an hour. A newcomer is advised 15

such sessions in a full course. AT is based on studies and research conducted by F. Matthias Alexander with the understanding that "you translate everything, whether physical, mental or spiritual into muscular tension".

Though little known in India, AT is a popular technique among physicians and practitioners across the world. It is one of the few alternative forms of healing that are fast becoming popular in India. While Menon's practice comprises only one-on-one interactive sessions, another equally popular technique, the Feldenkrais Method (FM), works with both one-on-one as well as group sessions. Similar



SANJAY RAMCHANDRAN/www.indiatodaymagazines.com

to AT in some ways, as both are based on movement, FM was founded by an Israeli physicist, Moshe Feldenkrais, who even gave lessons to the then Israeli prime minister David Ben Gurion, and has been popular in Europe for more than five decades with more than 3,000 people practising this method worldwide.

For centuries, the East has been the fountain of alternative therapy and cure with its famous exports to the West, including yoga, ayurveda, kalaripayattu and Tai Chi. A reversal of sorts is taking place with modern, well-researched methods, deeply rooted in scientific research from the

“Everyone knows that dance and music are therapeutic but we have no training centres to help us understand the scientific nature of these therapies.” BRUNDA JACOB, Dance Therapist